

11, The Striking Similarities Between Rome and China

Here, Rome and China share a substantial degree of similarity. In the process of Rome transforming the Mediterranean into its internal lake, the tribes and **communities** (社群) capable of maintaining local autonomy within its borders were significantly fewer compared to those in Persia and India.

By this period, the highly developed civilizational regions of the Eastern Mediterranean had already endured centuries of successful or unsuccessful rule by the Assyrians, the Persians, the Macedonians, and the Diadochi (马其顿的继业者们). Peaceful or violent interactions had already severely pulverized the existence of tribes and **communities** here.

For example, in Egypt, unlike previous conquerors of Egypt who seamlessly assumed the title of Pharaoh, the Roman Princeps (罗马元首) absolutely did not hold the title of Pharaoh; thereafter, there were never any Pharaohs again, and Egypt's political and cultural independence further collapsed. Another famous example is that the Romans initially fostered the Kingdom of Judea (犹太王国) in the Canaan region as a vassal state. However, as Rome entered the zenith of its **classical society** (古典社会), the Roman Empire gradually abolished Jewish autonomy through a series of hard and soft measures, directly annexing the entire Judean region into provinces for administration.

Western Europe, on the other hand, was far too backward; given the local levels of social development, it was exceedingly difficult to even establish autonomous political organizations within the empire (*a situation remarkably similar to Southern China*).

In fact, one can distinctly observe that the complexity and coercive power of Rome's bureaucratic system were glaringly superior to those of the **classical empires** (古典帝国) in Iran and India. It could absolutely rival the bureaucratic system of the Han Empire, exchanging blows on equal footing. For instance, in the judicial domain, the perfection and efficacy of the Roman Empire's bureaucracy were highly likely superior to those of the Han Dynasty. (*That Rome's bureaucracy was phenomenally formidable is practically a tautology that needs no elaboration; for if it were not strong, what possible reason could there be for the Byzantine Empire to survive another entire millennium after feudalization commenced?*)

Equally similar to China, the transition of social stages occurring in Rome during the classical period materialized earlier and far more conspicuously than in Iran and India.

The most representative exemplar of this is the Equestrian order (*Equites* / 骑士阶层) bridging the Republic and the Empire. Although this class existed as the second-highest social tier in Roman society (*classified by property standards*), its status was by no means immutable. For instance, during the transition from the Republic to the Imperial Principate (元首制), the Equestrian order massively filled administrative and military positions within the empire, most notably as Praetorian Prefects (禁卫军长官) and in key posts overseeing taxation.

According to the Roman historian Tacitus (塔西陀), the Roman Princeps deliberately elevated the Equestrian order precisely to counterbalance the Senate (元老院). This unequivocally demonstrates that such social class succession was likely an open secret back then. From the late Republic to the early Principate, the Equestrian order spawned a cohort of brilliant scholars, military commanders, administrative officials, and politicians, including Cicero (西塞罗), Pliny the Elder (老普林尼), Pliny the Younger (小普林尼), and Pompey (庞培).

As **feudalization** (封建化) progressed, the Equestrian order gradually evolved during the Imperial period into a stratum dominated by the **feudal landlord class** (地主阶级).

In the 1st century AD, as the economic returns of the slavery economy plummeted and the sources of slaves dwindled, the *Colonatus* system (隶农制) began to flourish. Ideologies critiquing slavery (such as those championed by the philosopher Seneca / 塞涅卡) and demands to partially replace slavery with the tenancy system (such as those of the agronomist Columella / 科卢梅拉) began to emerge.

With the massive expansion of the *coloni* (隶农) population and a substantial improvement in the living conditions of the remaining slaves, the exaction of land rent effectively supplanted forced labor as the primary mode of exploitation, and familial labor replaced collective labor. **This was the absolute prelude to feudalization.**

Judging from key phenomena such as the external manifestation of class succession, the development of tenancy relations (租佃关系), and the later rise of the **manorial economy** (庄园经济), the historical developmental trajectory of Han Dynasty China was slightly ahead of Rome. However, this lead should not exceed two centuries—a gap that was hardly significant in that era.

Numerous reasons can explain this disparity. China's social structure was simpler than that of the Roman world (*Rome at least retained the influence of city-state traditions, whereas city-state life and merchant burghers had severely decayed in China long before the Qin and Han periods; from another perspective, this also reflects China's longer historical development*).

China's population was far more concentrated than Rome's (*assuming both empires possessed roughly equal populations at their zenith, estimated between 60 and 70 million, China's densely populated zones were contiguous and concentrated in the middle and lower reaches of the Yellow River, whereas Rome's population was dispersed around the Mediterranean*).

Furthermore, the increasingly high-intensity warfare during the Spring and Autumn and Warring States periods violently accelerated technological innovations and applications (*such as iron weapons and agricultural tools*) and stimulated societal reforms (*although the warfare records of the Warring States period inevitably contain massive exaggerations, even if we discount the recorded military figures by half, the intensity of the wars remains staggeringly high*).

I wish to add a crucial point here: Many people believe that the wars of the Warring States period birthed a destructive bureaucratic system. **I absolutely reject this notion.**

First, up until the Qin Dynasty unified China, the Chinese bureaucratic system was not in the least bit perfected; it completely lacked even a relatively mature system for selecting officials. Otherwise, how could the Qin Dynasty have collapsed a mere dozen years after its unification? Second, as internal annexation wars within the civilized world on the eve of imperial unification, the wars of the Warring States period were not particularly unique in terms of their military mobilization ratios. They were not necessarily superior to the mobilization demonstrated by the Roman Republic during the Second Punic War (第二次布匿战争).

In terms of sheer brutality, while the Qin army's slaughter of prisoners of war was undeniably bloody, Rome's total annihilation of Carthage was hardly any better. However, the mobilization ratio of the "**Total War**" (总体战) launched by the Han Dynasty as a massive empire during the

Han-Xiongnu Wars and its expansionist campaigns was genuinely astronomically astonishing for the pre-modern era.

Additionally, one can also observe differences in specific details. After all, it is impossible for the political systems, historical trajectories, and geographical environments of the two empires to be perfectly identical.

For instance, when Rome transitioned from the zenith of its slavery economy to a feudal economy, it did not experience a period characterized by a massive population of independent yeomen (自耕农), unlike China's *classical empire*. Rome's abundance of independent yeomen existed *prior* to the explosive rise of its slavery economy. Rome's expansion brought prosperity to the slavery system, whereas the expansion of the Qin and Han empires consolidated *feudal economic relations* (封建经济关系)! Furthermore, the Chinese empires deliberately manufactured independent yeomen in newly conquered territories through "border colonization with migrants" (移民实边)—a policy exceptionally conspicuous during the reign of Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝).

An overwhelmingly autocratic ruler like Emperor Wu of Han would directly employ ruthless political means to crush large estate owners (大地产者). Roman rulers had no necessity to do this, nor could they necessarily achieve it even if they tried.

Nevertheless, regardless of whatever detailed discrepancies existed between the historical trajectories of the East and the West, the macro-historical progression up until the collapse of the *classical empires* remained fundamentally identical.

11，罗马与中国的相似性

在这里罗马和中国有一定的相似性，在罗马将地中海变为内海的过程中，其境内能够进行地方自治的部族和社群相对于波斯和印度就少了很多。这个时期东地中海的文明发达地区经亚述、波斯、马其顿以及马其顿的继业者们成功或者不成功的统治已经有数百年之久，和平或者暴力的交流已经削弱了部族和社群在这里的存在。例如在埃及，与先前埃及的征服者非常自然地拿过法老头衔不同，罗马元首不持有法老头衔，以后就再也没有法老了，埃及在政治上和文化上的独立性更加沦丧。另一个有名的例子则是罗马人在迦南地区最初扶植了犹太王国作为附庸国，但是当罗马进入古典社会的鼎盛年代后，罗马帝国就通过一系列或硬或软的方式逐步取消了犹太人的自治将整个犹太地区并入行省进行管理。而西欧又太过落后，以当地的社会发展水平连在帝国内建立自治的政治组织都是困难的（类似于中国南方）。实际上人们可以明显地发现，罗马的官僚体制复杂和强力程度明显还是要强于伊朗和印度的几个古典帝国，与汉帝国的官僚体制完全能说是互有胜负，例如在司法领域罗马帝国的官僚体制在完善性和起到的作用讲很可能就比汉朝要强一些。（罗马的官僚体制强大属于无须多言的废话，因为如果不强的话拜占庭有什么理由在封建化开始之后又存活了一千年）

与中国同样相似的是，罗马在古典时期发生的社会阶段过渡出现的时间比伊朗和印度要早一些，表现也要明显许多。最具代表性的就是从共和国时期到帝国时期的骑士阶层（*Equites*），这个阶层虽然作为罗马社会等级第二高的阶层存在（依财产标准划分），但是其地位并非不变。例如在由共和国转向帝国元首制的过程中，骑士阶层大量填补帝国的行政和军事职位，特别是禁卫军长官和对税务进行监督的要职。在罗马学者塔西陀（*Tacitus*）看来，罗马元首有意重用骑士阶层是出于对元老院的制衡，可见这种社会阶层的交替在当年恐怕都不是秘密。从共和国晚期到元首制早期骑士阶层涌现了一批杰出的学者，军事指挥官，行政官员还有政治家，包括西塞罗，老普林尼，小普林尼和庞培等。随着封建化的发展，骑士

阶层在帝国时期逐渐演变成以地主阶级为主体的阶层。在公元一世纪，隶农制随着奴隶制经济的收益下降以及奴隶来源的减少开始盛行，批判奴隶制的思想（哲学家塞涅卡\塞内卡\辛尼加 Seneca），用租佃制部分替代奴隶制的呼声（农学家科卢梅拉 Columella）开始出现。随着隶农群体的扩大和剩余奴隶处境大幅改善，缴纳地租已经代替强迫劳动成为主要的剥削方式，家庭劳动取代了集体劳动，这是封建化的先声。

从阶级更替的外显，租佃关系的发展以及更晚的庄园经济兴起这几个关键现象来看，汉代中国的历史发展进程要略微领先罗马，但是应当不超过两个世纪，该差距在当年算不上大。有不少理由可以解释这样的差距，包括中国社会的结构比罗马世界更加简单（罗马至少还有城邦传统的影响，但是城邦生活和商人市民在秦汉时期早就严重衰退了，从另一方面来讲这也是中国历史发展更久的原因），中国的人口比罗马集中得多（按罗马和汉朝在鼎盛时期人口持平，即 6000 万至 7000 万之间估计，中国的人口密集区集中在黄河中下游并且连片，而罗马的人口分散在地中海四周），春秋战国时期烈度越来越高的战争加速了技术革新和应用（比如铁制武器和农具），刺激了社会改革（虽然说战国时期的战争记录免不了大量注水，不过就算把历史记载的军队数量消减一半，战争的烈度依然很高）等等。这里想补充一点，很多人认为是战国时期的战争导致了破坏性的官僚制度，我并不认可这一点。其一是直到秦朝统一的时候中国的官僚制度一点都不完善，连比较成熟的选官制度都不存在，要不然秦朝怎么可能在统一之后十几年就灭亡。第二点是战国时期战争作为帝国统一前夕的文明世界内部的兼并战争，就其军事动员的比例而言也并非特殊，未必就比罗马共和国在第二次布匿战争中展现出的强。从惨烈程度来说，秦军屠杀战俘虽然血腥，不过罗马毁灭迦太基也不好到哪里去。然而汉匈战争以及汉扩张战争中汉朝作为一个大帝国发动的“总体战”的动员比例，在前现代时期就是极其惊人的了。

另外人们也能看到一些细节上的不同，毕竟两个帝国的政治体制，发展历史和所处环境不可能一模一样。例如罗马在从奴隶制经济的鼎盛时期向封建经济过渡的时候，没有像中国的古典帝国一样出现一个存在大量自耕农的时期，罗马存在大量自耕农是奴隶制经济勃兴前的事。罗马的扩张带来的是奴隶制的繁荣，而秦汉帝国的扩张巩固的是封建经济关系，并且有意在新征服的土地上通过移民实边制造自耕农（以汉武帝时期尤为明显）。像汉武帝这样极其强势的统治者会直接使用政治手段毫不留情地打击大地产者，罗马统治者没必要这样做也未必做得到。不过无论东西方历史进程在细节上有什么差异，直到古典帝国崩溃这个历史时期从整体上是一致的。